

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1993-03-05

To the bahá'ís of the world

1 dearly loved friends,

The kitáb-i-Aqdas—the book described in such exalted terms by the

2 guardian of the cause of god as “that priceless treasury enshrining for all
3 time the brightest emanations of the mind of bahá'u'lláh, the charter of
4 his world order, the chief repository of his laws, the harbinger of his

149 19a

150 message from The Universal House of Justice

151 Covenant, the pivotal work containing some of his noblest exhortations,
152 weightiest pronouncements, and portentous prophecies, and revealed dur-
153 ing the full tide of his tribulations, at a time when the rulers of the earth
154 had definitely forsaken him”150-1—this most holy book, we have the honor
155 to announce, will, in a copiously annotated english translation, be released
156 to the community of bahá at Naw-rúz.

bahá'u'lláh's own designations of the book—the “unnerring balance,”

157 the “Straight path,” the “quickener of mankind,” the “source of true felicity”
158 —indicate its phenomenal importance, an importance which staggers the mind
when viewed in light of the realization that this book is, in the

159 words of Shoghi effendi, the “principal repository of that law which the
160 prophet isaiah had anticipated, and which the writer of the Apocalypse had
161 described as the ‘new heaven’ and the ‘new earth,’ as ‘the Tabernacle of god,’
162 as the ‘holy city,’ as the ‘bride,’ the ‘New jerusalem coming down from

god.”

163 150-2 Such metaphors of hope have been recited from sacred scriptures

164 down the ages, have fired the imagination and excited the expectations of
unnumbered generations, and now, at long last, in this new dispensation,

have been given tangible form by the promised one of All Ages in this

165 mother book of his revelation.

166 The publication of the book in English satisfies a major goal of the Six year
167 plan. but even beyond this, it initiates the fulfillment of a prospect voiced by
168 'Abdu'l-bahá, who anticipated its publication in various languages; it real-
169 izes an intention cherished by Shoghi Effendi, who had himself translated
170 substantial portions of it into English which he diffused through his letters
171 and in his compilations of Bahá'u'lláh's writings, and who had also, "as an es-
172 sential prelude to the eventual translation and publication of its entire text,"
173 initiated steps in 1955 for the preparation of a Synopsis and codification of
174 the laws of the Kitáb-i-Aqdas. This was a task on which he made considerable
175 on the hundredth anniversary of the revelation of the book which occurred,
176 as Shoghi Effendi confirmed, "soon after Bahá'u'lláh had been transferred to
177 the house of 'Údí Khammár (circa 1873), at a time when he was still encom-
178 passed by the tribulations that had afflicted him, through the acts committed

by his enemies and the professed adherents of his faith."

179 150-3

180 150-1. p. 51.

181 150-2. gpb, p. 213. 150-3. mbw, p. 78; gpb, p. 213. 150.2

150 3

151 1992-1993 • The Holy Year

152 25 The accessibility to Western readers of the Kitáb-i-Aqdas in full authorized
153 text, for the first time in one of their major languages, enormously extends the
154 sphere of its influence, opening wider the door to a vast process of individ-
155 ual and community development which must certainly exert an increasingly
powerful, transformative effect on peoples and nations as the book is trans-
156 lated further into other languages. That the English edition of this highly
157 treasured and incalculably potent work should appear now amid the welter of a
world at odds with itself is a demonstration of confidence in the ultimate emergence of a
peaceful, civilized, global society. That it should be published during the period of the
centenary of both the Ascension of its divine Author

158 and the inauguration of his covenant amplifies the striking impact, already

159 felt, of the holy year which marks so important an anniversary.
 160 A book of such indescribable holiness is itself a symbol of the incom-
 161 parable greatness of the revelation of bahá'u'lláh and is, indeed, a potent
 162 reminder of the high respect which is due to all that has flowed from his
 163 prodigious, truth-bearing pen. may the friends of god ever be mindful of
 164 its exalted rank among the sacred texts of the faith; treasure it as the bread
 165 of life; regard possession of it as a sacred honor, as a priceless legacy from the
 166 pen of the most high, as a source of god's greatest bounty to his creatures;
 167 place their whole trust in its provisions; recite its verses; study its contents; adhere to
 its exhortations; and thus transform their lives in accordance with
 168 the divine standard.

169 let us rejoice. let us be filled with the felicitous spirit evoked in the blessed

beauty's own announcement of the mother book of his dispensation when

170 he said: " we announce unto everyone the joyful tidings concerning that

which we have revealed in our most holy book—a book from above whose

171 horizon the day-star of my commandments shineth upon every observer and
 172 every observed one." may we be such upholders of its laws and principles as
 173 to deserve his gloriously promised benediction: "b lessed those who peruse it.
 174 blessed those who apprehend it. blessed those who meditate upon it. blessed
 175 those who ponder its meaning. So vast is its range that it hath encompassed all
 176 men ere their recognition of it. ere long will its sovereign power, its pervasive
 177 influence and the greatness of its might be manifested on earth. verily, thy

god is the All-knowing, the All-informed."

178 150-4

179 150-4. Tb, pp. 267, 200.150.4

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151 1993–1996

The Three Year Plan

152 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

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Ridván Message 1 993

Ridván 150

To the b ahá'ís of the w orld

153 dearly loved f riends,

we have come to the king of festivals in the undiminished glow of

154 the marvelous benedictions of the holy year through which we have just

155 passed, confirmed, renewed and energized in our sacred pursuits. for it was

a time when the Abhá beauty shed upon his worldwide community the

156 radiance of his grace in such effulgence as to invest with astonishing success

157 the efforts of his followers to observe so significant a double anniversary as

158 the centenary of his Ascension and of the inauguration of his covenant.

159 it was the memorial pause that yielded a proclamation of the most great

160 Name that resounded throughout the earth as never before; but what was so

161 clearly an external phenomenon was quite markedly a reflection of an inner

162 attainment to a deeper understanding of our relation to bahá'u'lláh than

163 hitherto obtained. The greater appreciation in ourselves of the universality

164 of the community, of its embodiment of the first and overarching principle of his
faith, has left a new and compelling impression upon our hearts; the

165 effects of that awareness were strikingly demonstrated at the commemora-tion in the
holy land last may and more broadly at the world congress

166 last November, as if to confirm our assurance in these desperately troubled times that
the world of humanity is moving inexorably towards its as-yet

167 elusive destiny of unity and peace. indeed, during the holy year, we were

transported on the wings of the spirit to a summit from which we have

168 seen the fast-approaching glory of the lord's immemorial promise that all

169 humankind will one day be united.

170 The thrilling details of the happenings throughout the year are too nu-

171 merous to describe here, for the workings of the holy Spirit were universally

172 felt, imbuing the activities of the friends with a mysterious force. let it

173 suffice, then, to recall such highlights as the gathering last may of the larg-

174 est number of bahá'ís to participate in an event in the holy land; the

175 circumambulation of the Shrine of bahá'u'lláh by the representatives of
176 virtually every nation; the presence of the majority of the living knights
177 of bahá'u'lláh at the time of the depositing of the roll of honor at the en-
178 trance door of the most holy Shrine; the unprecedented size of the world 151.1

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152 1993–1996 • T h e T h r e e Y e a r P l a n

153 29congress and the vast variety of its participants, including a huge body of
154 youth who engaged in their own auxiliary program; the procession of the
155 representatives of the races and nations of the world on that spectacular
156 occasion; the satellite broadcast which linked the congress and the world

157 center with all the continents. These were of a rare category of experience, and they
have immortalized the fame of the centennial commemorations.

The innumerable, imaginative efforts undertaken by the friends around

158 the world, from remote villages to great cities, in observance of these im-portant
anniversaries illustrated afresh the profound degree to which the faith of bahá'u'lláh has
been consolidated, and they generated the teaching

159 work in many areas, with unusual and surprising results. The unprecedent-ed
publicity accorded the purpose and activities of the holy year through

160 the mass media in large and small countries, the notice given by legislative
161 bodies and public officials to the centennial, the gestures of recognition
162 and appreciation of the faith by governmental agencies, the involvement
163 of representatives of the bahá'í international community in major global

events, including the united Nations conference on environment and

164 development held in rio de janeiro last june, in connection with which a
165 public monument bearing an inscription from the writings of bahá'u'lláh

and a large imprint of the greatest Name was dedicated—such develop-

166 ments gave clear indications that the profile of the community has been
167 raised in the public eye.

Apart from all these outstanding events and developments, but of even

168 greater magnitude because of its far-reaching implications for the whole hu-man race,
was the release at Naw-rúz of the annotated english translation

169 of the kitáb-i-Aqdas, the most holy book. we draw a stage closer, then, to

170 a time envisaged by 'Abdu'l-b ahá: " when the laws of the most holy book
171 are enforced," the master said, "... universal peace will raise its tent in the
172 center of the earth, and the blessed Tree of life will grow and spread to such
an extent that it will overshadow the east and west."

173 151-1

174 The centennial year was also a period in which the situation in the world
175 at large became more confused and paradoxical: there were simultaneous signs of
order and chaos, promise and frustration. Amid the convolutions
176 of the current global state of affairs, but with such feelings of wonder and joy,
courage and faith as the holy year has induced in our hearts, we, at this

177 151-1. SA q, p. 164.151.3

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152 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

153 Oriḡván, in the one hundred and fiftieth year of our faith, are embarked
154 upon a Three year plan. its brevity is compelled by the swiftly changing
155 tides of the times. but the plan's primary purpose is indispensable to the fu-
156 ture of the cause and of humankind. it is the next stage in the unfoldment
157 of the divine charter of teaching penned by the center of the covenant.

158 The plan will be a measure of our determination to respond to the immense
159 opportunities at this critical moment in the social evolution of the planet.

160 Through resolute pursuit of its stated objectives and full realization of its goals, as
suited to the circumstances of each national community, the way will be made clear for a fit
projection of the role of the faith in relation to

161 the inevitable challenges facing all humanity towards the end of the fast-fleeting,
fate-laden twentieth century.

A massive expansion of the bahá'í community must be achieved far be-

162 yond all past records. The task of spreading the message to the generality

163 of mankind in villages, towns and cities must be rapidly extended. The need for this
is critical, for without it the laboriously erected agencies of the Administrative order will not
be provided the scope to be able to develop

164 and adequately demonstrate their inherent capacity to minister to the crying needs of
humanity in its hour of deepening despair. in this regard the mu-

165 tuality of teaching and administration must be fully understood and widely
emphasized, for each reinforces the other. The problems of society which
166 affect our community and those problems which naturally arise from within
167 the community itself, whether social, spiritual, economic or administrative, will be
solved as our numbers and resources multiply, and as at all levels
168 of the community the friends develop the ability, willingness, courage and
169 determination to obey the laws, apply the principles and administer the affairs of the
faith in accordance with divine precepts.

170 The new plan revolves around a triple theme: enhancing the vitality of
171 the faith of individual believers, greatly developing the human resources of the cause,
and fostering the proper functioning of local and national
172 bahá'í institutions. This is to lend focus to requisites of success as the plan's
173 manifold goals are pursued in these turbulent times.

Against the conspicuous signs of moral decadence which daily is cor-

174 roding the foundations of civilized life, these graphic words of bahá'u'lláh
175 assume an acute urgency: "The vitality of men's belief in god is dying out
176 in every land; nothing short of his wholesome medicine can ever restore
177 it. The corrosion of ungodliness is eating into the vitals of human society; what else
but the elixir of his potent revelation can cleanse and revive 151.6

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153 lit?" 151-2 Such words have particular implications for the actions of anyone
154 who has recognized the lord of the Age. A crucial consequence of this rec-
155 ognition is a belief that impels acceptance of his commandments. depth
156 of belief is assured by the inner transformation, that salutary acquisition
157 of spiritual and moral character, which is the outcome of obedience to the divine laws
and principles. Towards this end the release of the annotated
158 kitáb-i-Aqdas in english, and its anticipated early publication in other ma-
159 jor languages, provide a mighty infusion of divine guidance for realizing the
160 vitality of faith which is essential to the spiritual well-being and happiness of
individuals and the strengthening of the fabric of the community. No less
161 essential to nourishing this vitality is the cultivation of a sense of spiritual-

162 ity, that mystic feeling which unites the individual with god and is achieved
 163 through meditation and prayer.
 164 Training of the friends and their striving, through serious individual
 165 study, to acquire knowledge of the faith, to apply its principles and admin-
 166 ister its affairs, are indispensable to developing the human resources neces-sary to the
 progress of the cause. but knowledge alone is not adequate; it is
 167 vital that training be given in a manner that inspires love and devotion, fos-ters
 firmness in the covenant, prompts the individual to active participation
 168 in the work of the cause and to taking sound initiatives in the promotion
 169 of its interests. Special efforts to attract people of capacity to the faith will
 170 also go far towards providing the human resources so greatly needed at this time.
 moreover, these endeavors will stimulate and strengthen the ability of
 171 Spiritual Assemblies to meet their weighty responsibilities.
 172 The proper functioning of these institutions depends largely on the ef-
 173 ferts of their members to familiarize themselves with their duties and to adhere
 scrupulously to principle in their personal behavior and in the con-duct of their official
 responsibilities. of relevant importance, too, are their
 174 resolve to remove all traces of estrangement and sectarian tendencies from their
 midst, their ability to win the affection and support of the friends under their care and to
 involve as many individuals as possible in the work of the cause. by their constantly aiming
 at improving their performance,
 175 the communities they guide will reflect a pattern of life that will be a credit to the
 faith and will, as a welcome consequence, rekindle hope among the
 176 increasingly disillusioned members of society.
 177 151-2. gwb, no. 99.151.9
 151 10
 152 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e
 153 2As National Spiritual Assemblies, with the ready support of the conti-
 154 nental counselors, chart the course to be followed in this brief span, the
 155 world center will attend to coordinating widely diverse activities through-
 156 out the planet, giving further direction to the external affairs of the faith as
 157 the bahá'í international community is drawn more deeply into dealing with
 158 world issues. it will do this while at the same time pursuing with deliberate
 159 speed the gigantic building projects on god's holy mountain, which con-

160 stitute part of a process clearly perceived by Shoghi effendi as synchronizing
161 with two no less significant developments: the establishment of the lesser
162 peace and the evolution of bahá'í national and local institutions. by the end
163 of the plan all remaining construction phases of the mount carmel projects
164 will have been set in motion; the structural framework of the international
165 Teaching center, the center for the Study of the Texts and the extension
166 to the international Archives building will have been raised up; and seven
167 terraces below the Shrine of the báb will have been completed.

168 The dramatic expansion of the work of the cause in recent years and the

developments expected during this new plan demand material resources

169 which have not been adequate for some time, even though substantial in-
170 creases have been made in the contributions to bahá'í funds. The economic
171 crises so widely reported seem destined to grow even worse, but neither the
economic nor other pressing problems confronting humanity will ul-
172 timately be resolved unless the cause of bahá'u'lláh is given due regard by
173 nations and peoples and unless it receives the adequate material support of
174 its avowed adherents. may the friends everywhere consider, together with
175 their bahá'í institutions and individually, undaunted by the uncertainties,
176 the perils and the financial stringency afflicting nations, what must now be done by
each and all to meet this inescapable, sacred responsibility resting upon them.
177 our appeal for immediate, redoubled and sustained action on all aspects
178 of the plan is addressed primarily to the individual believer of every local-
179 ity, who possesses within himself or herself the measures of initiative that ensure the
success of any global bahá'í enterprise, and "on whom, in the
180 last resort," as our beloved guardian plainly stated, "depends the fate of

the entire community."

181 151-3 The goals of the Three year plan will not be
182 easily won, but they must be magnificently achieved, whatever the sacrifice.
183 There should therefore be no hesitation or delay on the part of individuals

184 151-3. cf , p. 130.151.11

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153 or Spiritual Assemblies in attending to them, lest the problems of mankind
154 pile up unchecked, or the rise of internal crises slows us down. let it ever be
155 borne in mind that we earn our victories through test and trial; we turn crisis to the
advantage of progress by seizing the opportunity it provides to dem-onstrate the viability
and winning power of our principles. in the onward
156 surge of the cause of god, crisis and victory have always alternated and
157 have ever proven to be the staple of progress. As we savor the triumphs of the holy
year, let us not forget the reality of this recurrent experience. let us
158 also remember that our blessings are equal to our challenges, as repeatedly shown by
our glorious history.

beloved friends: do not be dismayed or deterred. Take courage in the

159 security of god’s law and ordinances. These are the darkest hours before the
160 break of day. peace, as promised, will come at night’s end. press on to meet
161 the dawn.
162 152

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]